

crown prince—united by their survival instincts. They have a common enemy—BSP supremo Mayawati—and both remote control their parties. Amar Singh could not have missed the significance of that rendezvous: Rahul has never been seen hobnobbing with a non-Congress politician. And the First Family is not known for reaching out to people they need. They are more used to those knocks on the door from desperate souls. Then

LEADER FOLLOWS: Mulayam (centre) with his conscience keeper

tormentor like Amar Singh for survival in the wake of a Stalinist putsch is understandable. What Singh is good at today—splitting, poaching, tempting, twisting—is an art perfected by the vintage Congress. Unfortunately for the party and its fortified leader, there is none in the Congress today who can do an Amar. Look at this. When the Left accused the UPA of offering Rs 25 crore for a vote, Singh in no time produced an MP from his own party who accused Mayawati of offering Rs 30 crore to him. And when Advani, doubling himself as a punster who came lately, ridiculed



SIPRA DAS

THE IMPORTANCE OF AMAR SINGH

Total seats in Lok Sabha	541
Votes needed for majority	272
UPA-Left (289-59)	230
Votes needed by UPA	42

WHAT AMAR CAN SWING

Samajwadi Party	37
Other MPs*	12
Amar's total catch	49
UPA + SP + Others	279

*Independents and defections from other parties that Amar promises to bring in

what is it that makes the 'despicable' Amar Singh suddenly desirable?

Maybe his resume, replete with deals and coups. In 1990, he was a part of the team that broke the Janata Dal and played a crucial role in making Chandra Shekhar prime minister. Six years later, he was a decisive force in the election of H.D. Deve Gowda as prime minister. As Sonia famously failed in 1999 to produce the letter of support from '272' MPs, it was Singh who persuaded Mulayam to kill the lady's prime ministerial dream. In the 2002 presidential election, he defied the comrades and convinced his boss that NDA candidate A.P.J. Abdul Kalam was the right choice. And beyond politics, he is the best friend a bankrupt superstar or an industrialist in distress can ever get—ask Amitabh Bachchan or Anil Ambani, his soulmates.

In 2008, the stakes are higher, and he cannot afford to lose. He has promised the prime minister and Sonia that he would provide the winning numbers on July 22. The Congress predicament of suffering the ignominy of courting an erstwhile

He is the brand ambassador for a political

WRESTLER CALLED MULAYAM AND WORKS TO

build a ring larger than UP for the boss.

the somersaulting Singh as a member of the ruling party's new Dalaal Salaam culture, he immediately produced an autographed copy of the BJP leader's memoirs and asked: "Why was he so kind to a Dalaal?"

Still, Singh the newest friend of Sonia needs more than his maneuvering and soundbite skills to justify his—and SP's—support to the deal. Going by the old argument, SP cannot endorse the pro-American deal because it has to keep the vote-rich Muslim ghettos happy. It requires a convincing spin, and here it goes. According to Amar Singh, it's because of that honourable, venerable Muslim and former president Kalam. "Kalam is a Bharat